

Coupled with an aggressive campaign to get Coca-Cola's name plastered on everything from calendars to apothecary scales, coupons were at least partially responsible for Coca-Cola becoming a household name. For someone with such remarkable business sense, Candler proved to lack the foresight to imagine a future demand for a portable beverage. In 1899, he sold exclusive rights to bottle the drink for the grand sum of one dollar. Despite the success of the Coca-Cola campaign, the idea of using coupons as a promotional tool didn't immediately catch on. It wasn't until 1897 that C. W. Post issued a one-cent coupon to introduce his new breakfast cereal, Grape Nuts. Other cereal companies soon followed suit. Coupon use increased during the Depression when it was essential for families to find ways to stretch their budgets. Chain supermarkets began offering them in the 1940s as a way to draw customers away from neighborhood markets.

After the Depression, consumers kept up their habit of saving money through coupon clipping, and an entire industry developed. By 1957, there was a clearing house devoted solely to the redemption of coupons. Initially called the Nielson Coupon Clearing House, the name was eventually changed to the Manufacturers Coupon Control Center, or MC3.